

10 Things I've Learned by Grocery- Shopping on a Budget

I used to consider myself a frugal shopper, without following the cardinal rule of setting and sticking to a grocery budget. Inspired by Wise Bread and other websites, a few months ago I finally took the plunge and set an \$80 a week budget. I know that some people manage to spend as little as half that to feed a family of four (the two kids are little enough that they don't eat much), but for us \$80 has been a challenge.

Despite the challenges, I was pleased to find that the budget goal (some weeks it's been merely a goal) has taught me a few things about shopping and about myself:

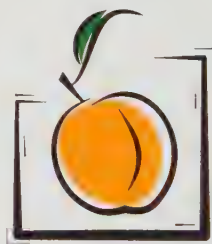
1. Coupons really do make a difference

I used to think that coupons would only tempt you into buying more expensive name-brand items, but lately

I've learned to do some online research, check my grocery flyers, and match up those coupons with items that are already discounted. I was delighted to learn that most stores will accept coupons even if the items are on clearance. The result is that almost every shopping trip, I get a couple things completely free.

2. While most cheap food is unhealthy, a lot of healthy food is cheap

When you're using coupons, you'll notice that some of those freebies are for food that a health-oriented person would not touch. Then there's the fact



that the meat that gets marked down to less than \$1 a pound is often fattier and almost never hormone- or antibiotic-free, grass-fed, or anything at all healthy.

But the flip side of this sad story is that some of the healthiest food is also some of the cheapest. I load up on in-season fruit and dried beans, and try to save a little room in the budget for some wild-caught salmon or some